Daisy Chains

by Michael Dean



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PAUL. Have you ever had the feeling that you're walking forward but moving backward? Like your metaphysical self is trying really hard to escape, but your stupidity has your body moving headlong toward a disaster?

Yeah…me neither.

The sticker on the welcome table reads "Hello, my name is _____." And I think, "Should I use an alias? If this thing goes sideways, do I need plausible deniability?" But I opt for the truth and write… Paul. There, that wasn't so hard.

Then I look up and find what seems like something out of *American Horror Story* or some demented haunted house: helpless and confused men sit in rows on backless stools in a gymnasium, staring blankly at the sharp instruments of torture on the table in front of them, looking into the dead eyes of dozens of severed mannequin heads.

Once again, I think, "Nope. Nope. Nope."

Just as my self-preservation instinct begins to suck me away toward the door, a bright and chipper voice echoes off the wood floors like basketball, "Hey, fellas. Welcome to Daddy Does Hair."

And I know that there's no getting out of this one.

During the 2016 Super Bowl, a commercial aired portraying NFL stars attempting, and mostly failing, to do their daughter's hair. That commercial was part of a global movement which challenged the gendered roles of fatherhood, and showed parenting as a skill that is learned. For single father, Paul, raising a daughter is all trial and error, yet his struggles remind us that the willingness to learn is at the root of all love. Daisy Chains by Michael Dean

PAUL. I find my seat between two guys who look even more uncomfortable than I do. We shake hands too hard—each asserting that we are men and that our masculinity is not threatened. It's the same way we puffed up when our daughters were first born. Everyone knew that one look—one tiny hand wrapped around a finger—and we were meltier on the inside than a bag of M&M's in a clothes dryer. But it doesn't matter. You still gotta play the part, walk tall, and drop your voice. Because, for a little while anyway, I was the manliest man she knew, then her mom left. And I had to become so much more.

My mannequin…whom I have named Wanda…has red hair, like my daughter's. It's a deep Irish red. When she was a baby, it was like the color of a sunrise, and now it's taking on this copper

warmth like my ex-wife's. Megan, that's her name. My daughter, not my ex-wife.

Megan was very clear on my assignment here: I am required to learn a looped French braid—or else.

It's for her dance recital next week. It's a big one. She's got a solo and everything. Shown it to me so many times, I bet I've even got it memorized.

So her hair has to be perfect, obviously.

The instructor starts the class by congratulating us on our bravery. She chuckles. We do not. there's no man here because it's chuckle time. In fact, I'd wager that if each of us hadn't been threatened in some way, shape, or form, we'd give all these mannequin's buzz cuts and head down to the bar to watch Monday Night Football.

Miss Chipper tells the class, "We'll start simple," "brush out the hair in long smooth strokes."

Well yeah, it's a hell of a lot easier when it's a mannequin, not a squirming rat's nest, squealing that it's taking too long.

Ok, next up is the flat iron. Miss Chipper says, "do it in layers and sections."

I look nervously at the guy next to me. He seems to know this part so I copy his moves, feeling once again entirely inadequate as the mannequin stares at me.

I clamp down on my finger and scream, "Holy hot hell! You want me to solder my kid's hair or what?"

I asked if one of the dance moms could handle the French braid, but Megan told me that it was time for us to figure it out for ourselves, which I agreed with thinking it meant that she would YouTube something or whatever and learn for herself. Then I found this flyer taped to my steering wheel.

Ten-year-old's are not known for their subtlety, I guess.

I like that about her. It's the part that reminds me of me. In these last two years on our own, I've developed a self-preservation instinct, but before that—whoa, I wouldn't just mess up. I made full-throated, whole-hearted, two-footed fails—usually because I tried too hard and said too much. This one time, Megan had this little second graders' singing show thing at school and the

directions that were sent home stated clearly that each child should dress as a flower for the performance.

And I thought to myself, "Well… Ok, then!"

I got tag board, wire, and elastic, and I made her this neon flower headdress. I made it big so she'd be the brightest flower in the garden. And then we got to the show… Well, I didn't know they were having the kids stand in rows and I didn't know she was standing in front. She eclipsed like half the class. But by god, you could've spotted that child from the moon!

Megan's mom said she couldn't believe I screwed it up. She was always saying she just "couldn't believe me." But somehow I knew she was talking more about believing *in* me. That's the part I failed at.

Wholeheartedly.

When someone stops believing in you, you lose them. In every possible way. You lose. And no matter how hard you try to make it right, eventually you're just punishing yourself. And I didn't blame her for not loving me anymore. I mean, some of that has to be beyond your control. But leaving me to explain it to an eight-year-old? No one deserves a punishment like that. Just because someone stops loving you doesn't mean you're right there saying, "Well, great. I was wondering if one of us was ever gonna fess up to this." Because I never would have. I never would have quit—I didn't.

The room looks at me briefly until the teacher chuckles again and I want to throw the mannequin head at her.

This isn't some joke.

Every day I see my daughter look more and more and more like her mother: the same hair, the same eyes, the same voice. And every day I feel us getting one step closer to that same disappointment. And the harder I try, the harder I fail. And while I used to be fine with that, there are different stakes now. And last night when she was telling me yet again about this stupid class, and I was trying to weasel out of it, she told me—yelled at me—you'd understand if you didn't have a mom!

And just like that, it's that same backwards feeling.

I try to be tough, but I'm not. Every day she's becoming this person who can see the world around her and everyone in it. Sooner or later, she'll realize what I've been dreading forever…

That I am probably not enough for her.

Miss Chipper stops by my workstation and sees the mess I've made of everything. I know she can see the tears forming in my eyes, and I just pray she doesn't chuckle at me.

"Paul?" She asks reading my nametag. She's asking if I'm okay. I don't know if I am.

"Yeah," I tell her. "I'm okay—just failing a little bit here."

"That's good. It means you're trying. Now brush it out and start again," she says.

And I think to myself, "That's the best thing you can say to a dad like me," because it's not a choice or a thing you can quit; failure's not an option. All you can do is hope you'll get a little better each time you try.